

ANI

TMC'S BALL CONTROL

The Mamata Banerjee government has a tight grip on Bengal's footballing landscape

- **Most local unregistered football tournaments are organised by local TMC leaders**
- **Handsome prize money is awarded to players as well as audiences**
- **Key TMC leaders such as Abhishek Banerjee, Madan Mitra, Aroop Biswas, Sujit Bose own football teams**
- **Rs 15 lakh each paid by two of these clubs as fee to the IFA for direct entry to first-division matches of Calcutta Football League**
- **TMC bigshots occupy key positions in Mohun Bagan, East Bengal, Mohammedan Sporting clubs**
- **Opposition accuses TMC of using clubs for politics**

to woo even the audiences. Paresh Ram Das, the Trinamool MLA from Canning West, organises an annual, eight-team knockout football tournament. This year, in every match, 20 select members of the audience will be rewarded; one 'lucky audience' will win a gold ring. According to posters of the event, 200 spectators at the final will win prizes and one person will get two motorbikes, a gold coin, a refrigerator... and 'a lot more'. This is in addition to the money and gifts for players and the winning team.

Ask where the money is coming from, and the answers are vague. Das himself could not be contacted and TMC sources would have you believe that a portion of the money is recovered through ticket sales and sponsorships.

There is no doubt, though, in the Opposition's mind. "How do you think TMC leaders fund these tournaments?" asks state BJP spokesperson Samik Bhattacharya. "This money is proceeds of crime from all the corruption and theft the TMC is involved in." His accusation is lent credence by the fact that two top officials from Mohun Bagan and East Bengal—Srinjoy Bose and Debabrata Sarkar, respectively—were arrested in 2014 by the CBI in connection with the multi-crore Saradha chit fund scam, which was the first corruption scandal to involve TMC leaders. Bose was a TMC MP in the Rajya Sabha between 2011 and 2015.

Football in Bengal is also a free-for-all. For any football match to be organised in Bengal, the tournaments or the clubs need to be registered with the IFA. However, the matches that the TMC organises are never questioned. "Not only are these tournaments illegal, the primary problem is the lack of facilities," says a senior official of the sports department. "The most alarming issue is lack of medical facilities. If a spectator or a player falls sick, there is no immediate treatment available." On October 29, Soumitra De, a 23-year-old player, collapsed during a match at Sabang in West Midnapore district, and was declared dead on arrival at the hospital. There was no medical response team on the spot. "The government doesn't plan to stand beside individual players," alleges the BJP's Bhattacharya. "Nor are they doing anything to develop the sport. All they want is to acquire football administration and use these agencies politically. The state infrastructure is crumbling, but the TMC is busy playing football."

A FILLIP FOR FOOTBALL

Not everyone is complaining, though. IFA secretary Anirban Dutta, for instance, lauds the efforts that the TMC government is making for the development of grassroots football. The Mamata Banerjee government, adds Dutta, gave the IFA Rs 25 lakh for the year 2022-2023 to organise inter-district tournaments. For the same fiscal, the association has also received another Rs 15 lakh from the government to organise the Kanyashree cup, a female-only football tournament ideated by the chief minister herself. "We get every form of help from the government, its vision of developing football is laudable," says Dutta.

However, sources in the IFA claim that the picture isn't as rosy. The IFA has a debt of around Rs 6.5 crore, and couldn't organise its marquee tournament, the IFA Shield, in 2022-2023 because of a cash crunch. Several IFA officials tell INDIA TODAY that funds from the budget of the sports and youth affairs department should be used to help the IFA recover financially. The total budget estimation for the department for the current fiscal is Rs 788.30 crore. Much of this has been spent on building new stadiums across the state. The IFA has to mind current political realities too. "The Union sports ministry had offered us Rs 2.15 crore to organise 60 women's football matches under the Khelo India campaign. But we could not accept it because of the political tussle between the TMC and the BJP," says an IFA source.

There is no denying the money and energy that the Mamata Banerjee government and Trinamool have invested in football, much of which has been directed towards the development of the game. The question is whether the political use of football is beginning to overshadow the charm and spirit of the game in the state. ■